

STEELSTOWN PARISH NEWSLETTER

Sunday, 23rd August 2026

21st Sunday in Ordinary Time

Thoughts on the Gospel

“You are Peter, and on this rock I will build my Church.” — Matthew 16:18

In today’s Gospel, Jesus asks His disciples a very personal question about who they believe He is. Many people had different opinions about Him, but Jesus wanted His followers to speak from their own faith and experience.

Peter answers with confidence, recognising Jesus as the promised Saviour and the Son of God.

This passage reminds us that faith cannot depend only on what others believe. We may learn about God from our parents, teachers, friends or church community, but each of us must eventually make our own response to Jesus.

Remember the word **ROCK**

R — RECOGNISE Jesus as Lord and Saviour.

O — OWN our faith through our daily choices.

C — COMMIT to the calling God gives us.

K — KEEP standing firm when life becomes difficult.

Peter was not perfect, yet Jesus still used him for a great purpose. In the same way, God can work through our weaknesses and help us become part of His mission.

When we build our lives on Christ, our faith becomes stronger, our hope grows deeper, and our lives show the answer to Jesus’ question. Our response should not be seen only in our words, but also in how we love, forgive, serve and remain faithful.

Christ is the true foundation, and when we stand on Him, life’s storms may shake us, but they cannot destroy the hope He gives.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, you are the Messiah, the Son of the living God. Strengthen our faith to confess You with courage. May nothing overcome the hope we have in You.

Liturgy & Prayer

Readings for Sunday 30th August

1st Reading: Jeremiah 20:7-9

Psalm: 62:2-6, 8-9

2nd Reading: Romans 12:1-2

Gospel: Matthew 16:21-27



Saints of the Coming Week

Monday: St Bartholomew, Apostle

Tuesday: St Joseph Calasanz, priest; St Louis

Thursday: St Monica

Friday: St Augustine, bishop & doctor of the Church

Saturday: The Passion of St John the Baptist, martyr



Faith & Spiritual Life

Embrace the Grace

Legion of Mary Young Adult (18-40) Catholic Conference



Saturday 29th August



9.30 am - 6 pm



De Montfort House, Morning Star Ave, Dublin, D07 VA03

Tickets from Eventbrite. Search “**Embrace the Grace.**”



Please Pray for Vocations

Visit **derryvocations.org**



Sharing the Good News

Visit **theway.ie/ezine-2/** for the weekly ezine.



Lough Derg Day Retreats

August: 29 & 31

September: 5, 6, 9, 12, 15, 19 & 20

Take time away from the busyness of life for a day of guided prayer, quiet reflection and spiritual renewal in the peaceful surroundings of Lough Derg.

Visit **loughderg.org**

St Joseph's Men's Camino 2026

A day of **pilgrimage, prayer, brotherhood and renewal.**

Saturday 12th September

Step away from the demands of everyday life and spend a day walking with Christ alongside other Catholic men.

Inspired by the ancient tradition of pilgrimage, St Joseph Men's Camino is a **25km guided pilgrimage along the beautiful Boyne Valley Camino.**

Open to men aged 18 and over.

Cost: €65 (includes lunch & dinner)

Students: €55

Visit **dominicans.ie**

Contemplative Prayer Group

The Contemplative Prayer Group meets on **Mondays at 8 pm** in the Prayer Room in the Parochial House, Barrack St.

All welcome.

Family & Marriage

Catholic Mothers Ireland Family Day

Sunday 6th September

 Termonbacca Retreat Centre, Derry

 Beginning with the **National Mass at 2 pm**, celebrated by Bishop McKeown.

The Mass will be followed by refreshments, children's activities and a talk for parents. This promises to be a lovely day for the whole family.

For information / to book: info@catholicmothers.ie

All welcome.

Accord Derry Marriage Preparation

Marriage Preparation Course for those getting married in **late 2026 / early 2027.**

Next dates:

- September 25th/26th 2026
- November 20th/21st 2026

Please note that Accord Derry will **NOT** be facilitating courses during October or December 2026.

Register online at **accordni.com**

Marriage Enrichment Weekend

Marriage Encounter invites married couples to a residential weekend:

 **2nd - 4th October**

 Focolare Centre, Prosperous, Kildare

Step away from daily distractions to deepen your communication, renew your love and rediscover the joy of your marriage.

Visit **marriageencounter.ie**

Parish & Community Notices

Buncrana Annual Garden Fete

Today (Sunday), 3 - 6 pm

 Grounds of Scoil Mhuire, Buncrana, F93 PN53

Fun for all the family with Bouncy Castles, Mechanical Bull, Petting Farm, Facepainting, Bingo, Rickety Wheel, Children's Games, Raffle Prizes, etc.

Entry: €5pp / €15 per family (*cash only*)

All welcome.

Coffee Morning in Aid of Foyle Hospice

 **Friday 25th September**

 **9.30 am - 12.30 pm**

 Murphy's on the Green

Prize draw: £1 per line.

All welcome.

Michael English Church Concert

An Evening of Faith, Hope and Inspiration

 **Friday 2nd October**

 **7.15 pm**

 St Patrick's Church, Keenaught, Desertmartin

Tickets: £30

Available at Heron's Gift Shop, Draperstown, Moneyneena PO, Ballinascreen, Desertmartin Parish or through Eventbrite.

Reflections Through Poetry

Reflections Through Poetry by **Fr John P Forbes** is available in the Pastoral Office.

Cost: £10

Proceeds to **Children in Crossfire** and **Cause for Sr Clare's Canonisation**.

Support & Wellbeing

RISE

A vital new community initiative, **RISE** is dedicated to supporting the families, friends and loved ones of those living with addiction.

 **Sunday 13th September**

 **12 noon - 4 pm**

 Everglades Hotel, Derry

The gathering aims to bring together people who may feel isolated, overwhelmed or unaware of the support structures available to them as they navigate a loved one's addiction.

The foundational message of RISE is that **recovery and healing involve the whole family**. The day is designed to serve as a safe, welcoming space where people can share experiences, build meaningful connections and discover where they can turn for help.

To secure your place, send a direct message via Facebook Messenger to the official page.

Family Carers Ireland

Family Carers Ireland are running **1:1 support clinics remotely every Tuesday in August** for carers, offering you a space and time to talk over the phone in the comfort of your own home.

 **086 8363842**

 Donegalcs@familycarers.ie

Alzheimer's Society — Carers' Information Support Programme

The Alzheimer's Society is running a **Carers' Information Support Programme (CRISP)** for family, carers and friends of people living with dementia in the Omagh area.

The programme is run over two sessions and attendees should attend both afternoons.

 **7th & 8th September 2026**

 **3 - 5 pm**

 Conference Room, Silver Birch Hotel, 5 Gortin Road, Omagh

To register, please contact **Julie-Anne, Senior Dementia Adviser**.

 **07889 604702**

Registration is required prior to attendance.

Vacancies

Derry Diocesan Trust — Job Opportunity

Administrative & Financial Officer

 Waterside Parish, Derry

 **18 hrs pw**

 **£12.88 - £13.50 per hour**

For further information:

 recruitment@derrydiocese.org

 **028 71262302**

Closing date: 24/8/26

Personal Assistants Wanted

The Churches Trust is recruiting people for flexible part-time work supporting and befriending elderly people living independently at home.

No experience required – **training and support provided.**

A full clean driving licence and access to a vehicle are required.

 For more information, call **02871 311322.**

Fundraising

Lough Derg Annual Fundraising Draw

Help ensure **Station Island remains open for future generations.**

 **Single ticket: €10**

 **Book of 6: €50**

Buy a full book and you're entered into a **sellers' draw.**

Return a complete book for the **Early Bird Draw on 28/8/26.**

 **Main Draw: 23/10/26**

Tickets from loughderg.org/store/c3/annualdraw

 +353 (0) 71 9861518

 info@loughderg.org

Pilgrimage

Medjugorje Pilgrimage

 **23rd - 30th September**

 **Cost: €775 pps**

A Thought for the Week

“You are the Messiah, the Son of the living God.” — Matthew 16:16

May we recognise Christ, own our faith, commit ourselves to His calling and keep standing firm in Him.

R • O • C • K ?